



STUDENT GUIDE & WORKBOOK MODULE 2: TOPIC 2

www.professionalyear.info

'More than a great education'

Cohort Number	
Student Name	
Student Number	
Mobile Number	
Email Address	

CONTENTS

TOPIC 2 – OFFICE POLITICS AND CONFLICT

RESOLUTION	4
7 WAYS TO USE OFFICE POLITICS POSITIVELY	4
GETTING WHAT YOU WANT WITHOUT "PLAYING DIRTY"	4
HOW POLITICAL IS YOUR WORKPLACE?	4
7 SURVIVAL TIPS FOR OFFICE POLITICS	5
1. ANALYSE THE ORGANISATION CHART.....	5
2. UNDERSTAND THE INFORMAL NETWORK.....	5
3. BUILD CONNECTIONS.....	6
4. DEVELOP YOUR “PEOPLE SKILLS”	10
5. MAKE THE MOST OF YOUR NETWORK.....	6
6. BE BRAVE BUT NOT NAÏVE	7
7. NEUTRALISE NEGATIVE POLITICS	7
ASSERTIVE, AGGRESSIVE AND PASSIVE COMMUNICATION STYLES.....	8
HOW ASSERTIVE ARE YOU?	10
PUTTING LANGUAGE INTO PRACTICE.....	10
CONFIDENCE THROUGH ASSERTION	11
DISC.....	12



TOPIC 2

OFFICE POLITICS AND CONFLICT RESOLUTION

"Peace is not absence of conflict; it is the ability to handle conflict by peaceful means."

Ronald Reagan

7 WAYS TO USE OFFICE POLITICS POSITIVELY

https://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newCDV_85.htm

Getting what you want without "Playing Dirty"

What do you think of when you hear the words "office politics"? Is it all about "backstabbing," spreading malicious rumors, and "sucking up" to the right people? If so, you'll likely want to stay as far away from it as you can!

But, like it or loathe it, office politics are a fact of life in any organization. And it **is** possible to promote yourself and your cause without compromising your values or those of your organization.

Practicing "good" politics enables you to further your and your team's interests fairly and appropriately. And, being alert to the "bad" politics around you helps to avoid needless suffering while others take advantage.

In this article, we examine why workplace politics exist, and look at seven ways to "win" at office politics without sinking to the lowest standards of behaviour.

How Political is your Workplace?

All workplaces are political to some extent, simply because people bring their personal emotions, needs, ambitions, and insecurities into their professional lives.



We all want to be successful, but we don't always agree with one another about what this means or how we should achieve it. Office politics arise when these differences of personality and opinion become difficult to manage.

And we often care deeply about the decisions that we make, or that others make about us, so we seek to influence people's choices. We can be straightforward or underhand about this.

Also, remember that some people will always have more power than others, either through hierarchy or some other source – you can explore this with our article, [French and Raven's Five Forms of Power](#) . It's natural to want to use, or increase, our power, but we might do so in a way that takes power away from others.

Finally, organizations have limited resources. This can lead to teams competing to satisfy their own needs and goals, even when this may go against the "greater good."

7 SURVIVAL TIPS FOR OFFICE POLITICS

https://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newCDV_85.htm

The foundation for making politics work for you in a positive way is to accept it as a reality. It may change over time, as people come and go in your organization, but chances are it will never disappear entirely.

Then, you need to develop strategies to recognize and understand political behaviour and to build a strong and supportive network.

These seven tips can help you to do this:

1. Analyse the Organisation Chart

Office politics often circumvent the formal organizational structure. So, sit back and observe for a while, and then [map the political power and influence](#) in your organization, rather than people's rank or job title.

To do this, ask yourself questions like, "Who are the real influencers?," "Who has authority but tends not to exercise it?," "Who is respected?," "Who champions or mentors others?," and "Who is the brains behind the business?"

2. Understand the Informal Network

Once you know where the power and influence lie, it's time to examine people's interactions and relationships to understand the informal or social networks.

Watch closely (but discreetly and respectfully) to find out who gets along with who, and who finds it more difficult to interact with others. Look for [in-groups, out-groups or](#)



[cliques](#) . Notice whether connections are based on friendship, respect, romance, or something else.

Finally, try to decipher how influence flows between the parties, and whether there are any interpersonal conflicts, or examples of bullying.

If you believe that you or someone else in your organization is being bullied, take a look at our articles [Dealing With Bullying](#) and [Dealing With Bullying on Your Team](#) . Both articles list the types of bullying behaviours to look out for, as well as tips on how to confront and prevent bullying in the workplace.

3. Build Connections

Now that you know how existing relationships work, you can start to build your own social network.

Look beyond your immediate team and cross the formal hierarchy in all directions – co-workers, managers and executives. Don't be afraid of politically powerful people. Instead, get to know them, and build [high-quality connections](#) that avoid empty flattery.

Be friendly with everyone but avoid aligning yourself too closely with one group or another. And, if you're considering a [personal relationship at work](#) , be certain to base it on consent, to avoid any suggestion of illegal or inappropriate influence, and to never break confidentiality.

***Tip:** Read our articles on [Stakeholder Analysis](#) and [Stakeholder Management](#) to learn about a formal way to identify influencers and to gain their support.*

4. Develop your "People Skills"

As we've seen, politics are all about people, so strong [Interpersonal Skills](#) will stand you in good stead when it comes to building and maintaining your network.

Reflect on your emotions, what prompts them, and how you handle them. If you can learn to self-regulate, you'll be able to think before you act. This kind of emotional intelligence helps you to pick up on other people's emotions, too, and to understand what kind of approach they like or dislike.

Learn to [listen carefully](#) , too. When you invest time in listening, you'll slow down, focus, and learn. And, people like people who listen to them!

***Tip:** Take [quiz](#) to assess your own level of emotional intelligence.*

5. Make the Most of your Network

Through your relationships, you can build [your personal brand](#) and [raise your team's profile](#) .



When you communicate your achievements to your connections, they might open opportunities to "shine" for you, your team, and your boss. They can also act as a "bridge" between you and other colleagues.

Warning: *Exercise caution when you leverage your network in this way – you don't want to get a reputation as a "pest!" Always keep your organization's goals in mind, and don't "badmouth" others, or you'll make more enemies than friends. Instead, become known for using "positive political action."*

It's also crucial to be [accountable](#) for your actions. This demonstrates your honesty and integrity. So, ask for feedback from others who may have a different perspective on your work. This is a good way to find out what's most important to the people in your network, and it shows that you value their opinions.

6. Be Brave – but not Naïve

Your first instinct may be to keep your distance from people who practice "bad" politics. In fact, the opposite can be more effective. The expression, "Keep your friends close and your enemies closer," often applies to office politics.

So, get to know the gossips and manipulators better. Be courteous but guarded, as they may repeat what you say with a negative "spin." Try to understand their goals, so that you can avoid or counter the impact of their negative politicking. And be aware that some people behave badly because they feel insecure – this is a form of [self-sabotage](#).

However, protect yourself as much as possible from anyone you suspect of Machiavellianism or another of the [Dark Triad](#) of characteristics. Such people are very likely clever and dangerous.

7. Neutralise Negative Politics

You can help to make a workplace become more positive by not "fuelling the fire" and joining in negative politics.

For example, avoid passing on [rumors](#) without taking time to carefully consider their source, credibility and impact. And don't rely on confidentiality. It's safer to assume that whatever you say will be repeated, so choose carefully what "secrets" you reveal.

Remain [professional](#) at all times, and don't take sides, or get sucked into arguments or recriminations. When a conflict arises, remember that there doesn't have to be a winner and a loser. It's often possible to find a solution that satisfies everyone.

If you're [voicing concerns or criticism](#) of your own, be confident and assertive but not aggressive. And make sure that you take an organizational perspective, and not simply a selfish one.

Note: If you're working in a particularly "toxic" atmosphere, read our article, [Working in a Highly Political Organisation](#). This draws on Professor Kathleen Kelley Reardon's classification of four types of political organisation and offers more tips for surviving them.

Key Points

Office politics are a reality that we all must face and avoiding them altogether risks not having a say in what happens. It also allows people with less experience, skill or knowledge than you to influence decisions that affect you and your team.

"Good" politics can help you to get what you want without harming others in the process. To harness its power:

1. Analyse the organisation chart
2. Understand the informal network
3. Build relationships
4. Make the most of your network
5. Develop your "people skills"
6. Be brave – but not naive
7. Neutralise negative politics

ASSERTIVE, AGGRESSIVE AND PASSIVE COMMUNICATION STYLES

<https://www.aifc.com.au/communication-styles/>

As individuals we often dress, look, communicate and express ourselves in a variety of different ways. When communicating with one another we might come across to others as assertive but nice, way too nice and trying too hard or just plain aggressive.

In what ways are these communication styles different from each other?



ASSERTIVE COMMUNICATION – Allows us to express our beliefs, feelings, opinions and thoughts in an open respectful manner that doesn't violate the rights of others. Assertive communicators use actions and words to express their boundaries in a calm manner with an air of confidence.

The benefits of adopting an assertive communication style are: earning the respect of others and boosting your own self esteem.

AGGRESSIVE COMMUNICATION – Quite often people mistake assertiveness for aggression. Aggressiveness doesn't hold any respect for others. It disregards anyone's needs, feelings, opinions and ideas and sometimes this can compromise the safety of others as well.



Aggressive communicators are easily identified by their demanding.

PASSIVE COMMUNICATORS – Silence and assumption are the hallmarks of the passive communication style. Passive communicators often lack of respect for themselves, disregarding their own opinions, feelings, needs, and desires. Passive communication places one's own needs and desires below those of others. Passivity takes away one's power and allows others to decide the outcomes of situations.

"Passive communicators hesitate, they might be quiet, self-dismissing or put themselves down. Often they have body language that might include covering the mouth, looking down, avoiding eye contact, crossed arms and placing their hand over their mouth to cover."

Sandra Ciminelli
Cred. Dip.Couns.

1. Activity – How Assertive are you?

Access the link to take the following test. Answer questions honestly to discover your communication style:

<https://www.activia.co.uk/assertiveness-test>

2. Activity – Putting Language into Practice

Instructions:

- In groups of 3 or 4 read the following situations and discuss different responses.
- Prepare a dialogue (Role play) Assertive Response.
- Be ready to share this with class

Communication Practice

Situation 1: You and Ben share a desk at work as you work different shifts. Ben tends to leave the desk in a very untidy state. You feel very angry when you come to see the desk as you find it difficult to find your things. How do you address this issue with Ben?

Passive Response:

Aggressive Response:

Assertive Response:

Situation 2: You feel you are underpaid and believe you are a good worker. You feel frustrated your employer does not recognise this and raise your salary. How would you address this situation?

Passive Response:

Aggressive Response:

Assertive Response:



Situation 3: Your employer criticises you in front of your colleagues. You feel humiliated and angry. What would you do in this situation?

Passive Response:

Aggressive Response:

Assertive Response:

Situation 4: A work colleague comes into your office without knowing and starts a conversation about her issues with her boyfriend. You have a deadline to finish your work and are running behind. How would you handle this situation?

Passive Response:

Aggressive Response:

Assertive Response:

3. Activity – YouTube Video – Confidence through Assertion

Access the following link to discover 5 Easy Ways to Sound More Confident with Assertive Language in English:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9Yg1HP35pSw>

4. Activity – DISC

Instructions:

- Choose one word in each line which best describes your natural behaviour or approach and circle the letter following it
- In “your response” box below, tally the number of D’s, I’s etc. and write the total against the appropriate letter
- Write down your DISC results in the space provided
- Upload your assessment in your assessment file on CANVAS



Strengths

Adventurous	D	☐	Adaptable	S	☐	Animated	I	☐	Analytical	C	☐
Persistent	C	☐	Playful	I	☐	Persuasive	D	☐	Peaceful	S	☐
Submissive	S	☐	Self-sacrificing	C	☐	Sociable	I	☐	Strong-willed	D	☐
Considerate	C	☐	Controlled	S	☐	Competitive	D	☐	Convincing	I	☐
Refreshing	I	☐	Respectful	C	☐	Reserved	S	☐	Resourceful	D	☐
Satisfied	S	☐	Sensitive	C	☐	Self-reliant	D	☐	Spirited	I	☐
Planner	C	☐	Patient	S	☐	Positive	D	☐	Promoter	I	☐
Sure	D	☐	Spontaneous	I	☐	Scheduled	C	☐	Shy	S	☐
Orderly	C	☐	Obliging	S	☐	Outspoken	D	☐	Optimistic	I	☐
Friendly	S	☐	Faithful	C	☐	Funny	I	☐	Forceful	D	☐
Daring	D	☐	Delightful	I	☐	Diplomatic	S	☐	Detailed	C	☐
Cheerful	I	☐	Consistent	S	☐	Cultures	C	☐	Confident	D	☐
Idealistic	C	☐	Independent	D	☐	Inoffensive	S	☐	Inspiring	I	☐
Demonstrative	I	☐	Decisive	D	☐	Dry Humour	S	☐	Deep	C	☐
Mediator	S	☐	Musical	C	☐	Mover	D	☐	Mixes easily	I	☐
Thoughtful	C	☐	Tenacious	D	☐	Talker	I	☐	Tolerant	S	☐
Listener	S	☐	Loyal	C	☐	Leader	D	☐	Lively	I	☐
Contented	S	☐	Chief	D	☐	Chart maker	C	☐	Cute	I	☐
Perfectionist	C	☐	Pleasant	S	☐	Productive	D	☐	Popular	I	☐
Bouncy	I	☐	Bold	D	☐	Behaved	C	☐	Balanced	S	☐

Opportunities

Blank	S	☐	Bashful	C	☐	Brassy	I	☐	Bossy	D	☐
Undisciplined	I	☐	Unsympathetic	D	☐	Unenthusiastic	S	☐	Unforgiving	C	☐
Reticent	S	☐	Resentful	C	☐	Resistant	D	☐	Repetitious	I	☐
Fussy	C	☐	Fearful	S	☐	Forgetful	I	☐	Frank	D	☐
Impatient	D	☐	Insecure	C	☐	Indecisive	S	☐	Interrupts	I	☐
Unpopular	C	☐	Uninvolved	S	☐	Unpredictable	I	☐	Unaffectionate	D	☐
Headstrong	D	☐	Haphazard	I	☐	Hard to please	I	☐	Hesitant	S	☐
Plain	S	☐	Pessimistic	C	☐	Proud	D	☐	Permissive	I	☐
Angered easily	I	☐	Aimless	S	☐	Augmentative	D	☐	Alienated	C	☐
Naïve	I	☐	Negative Attitude	C	☐	Nervy	D	☐	Nonchalant	S	☐
Worrier	S	☐	Withdrawn	C	☐	Workaholic	D	☐	Wants credit	I	☐
Too sensitive	C	☐	Tactless	D	☐	Timid	S	☐	Talkative	I	☐
Doubtful	S	☐	Disorganised	I	☐	Domineering	D	☐	Depressed	C	☐
Inconsistent	I	☐	Introvert	C	☐	Intolerant	D	☐	Indifferent	S	☐
Messy	I	☐	Moody	C	☐	Mumbles	S	☐	Manipulative	D	☐
Slow	S	☐	Stubborn	D	☐	Show-off	I	☐	Sceptical	C	☐
Loner	C	☐	Lord over others	D	☐	Lazy	S	☐	Loud	I	☐
Sluggish	S	☐	Suspicious	C	☐	Short-tempered	D	☐	Scatter brained	I	☐
Revengeful	C	☐	Restless	I	☐	Reluctant	S	☐	Rash	D	☐
Compromising	S	☐	Critical	C	☐	Crafty	D	☐	Changeable	I	☐

Task:

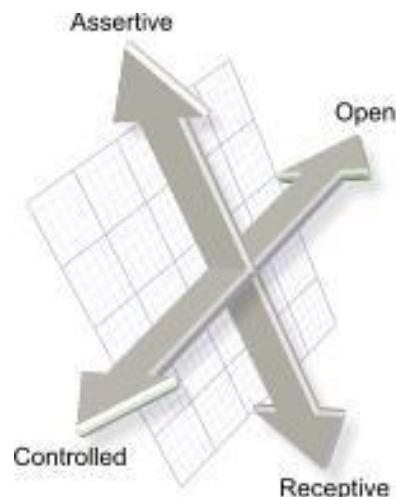
Please fill the boxes with colour according to your DISC results to analyse your Behavioural Styles.

20				
15				
10				
5				

PERSONALITY TYPES AND DiSC®

Human personalities are highly varied and complex, and the full

DiSC® system is designed to reflect that variation and complexity, but sometimes it can be useful to break down personalities into a few fundamental types.



We can do that with DiSC® because at its deepest level, it is based on a pair of simple personality axes. The first of these is a continuum between Assertiveness (pro-active, direct behaviour) and Receptiveness (responsive, reticent behaviour). The second describes a scale from Openness (sociability, expressiveness) and Control (reticence and caution). Taken together, these two axes form a grid, and by placing a personality somewhere on this grid, we can draw all sorts of useful conclusions.

Four Personality Types, and Four More

Sometimes one of the four fundamental styles will predominate in a person's approach to life, and so we get our first four basic personality types: Assertive, Receptive, Open and Controlled.

Just as often, though, a personality will combine elements from two of the axes, so (for example) we'll find a person who's both Assertive and Open, or both Receptive and Controlled. There are four possible combinations like this, and together they give us another four personality types: Dominant, Influential, Steady and Compliant. (These latter four in fact give rise to the four DiSC® factors, and their initials give 'DiSC®' its name).



A Grid of Personality Types

We have laid out these eight below according to where they fall on the two major DiSC® axes. For each of the eight types you'll see a checklist describing the type of personality associated with that type.

Concepts in Communication

- We can effectively work together with all styles, provided that we have:
- Mutual respect
- Mutual trust
- Willingness to adapt

Theoretical basis of DiSC®

- Similar styles tend to be compatible socially
- Work task effectiveness is strengthened by mixing different styles
- Mixing different styles may result in interpersonal conflict
- Understanding of self and others can lead to better communication and workplace effectiveness

DiSC® does not:

- Have right or wrong
- Measure IQ or EQ

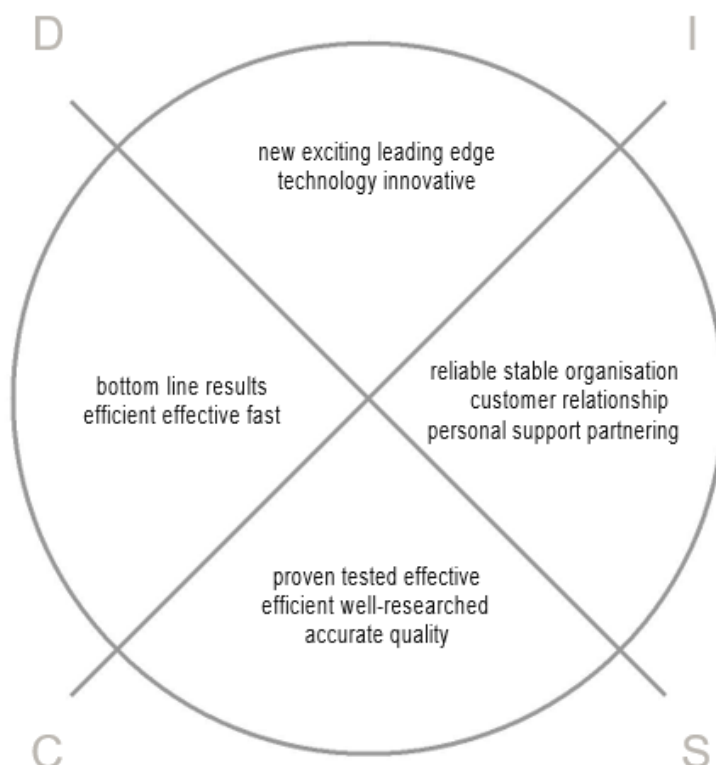
Dominance
Driver
Fire
Power

Influence
Expressive
Air
Expression

Extroverted



Introverted



Task Oriented

People Oriented

Conscientiousness
Compliance
Control
Earth
Perfection

Steadiness
Supporter
Amiable
Water
Peaceful

Dominance

Recognise by	• High self-confidence, ego strength • Assertiveness, can be forceful • Interpersonal competitiveness
Prefers work environment to be	• Busy, formal, faster pace
Gains security by	• Being in control, having a plan
Motivated by	• Achievement
Measure progress by	• Results, preferably immediate
Fears	• Being taken advantage of
Irritated by	• Inefficiency, loss of control, indecision, slowness
Major Limitation	• Impatience, selective listening • Under pressure, may show lack of concern for others views and feelings
Could increase effectiveness by	• Developing patience and listening skills

Influence

Recognise by	• Talkativeness, enthusiasm • Optimism, persuasiveness • Energy
Prefers work environment to be	• Stimulating, personal, friendly • Faster pace
Gains security by	• Flexibility, variety
Motivated by	• Social recognition
Measure progress by	• Applause, praise
Fears	• Social rejection, being ignored
Irritated by	• Routine, formality • Structure
Major Limitation	• Lack of follow-through • Under pressure, can become disorganised
Could increase effectiveness by	• Self-discipline • Follow through on tasks

Steadiness (Supporter)

Recognise by	• Friendliness, co-operation • People and task-oriented
Prefers work environment to be	• Relaxed, personal, friendly • Team oriented • Slower pace
Gains security by	• Close, stable relationships
Motivated by	• Unconditional acceptance • Stability
Measure progress by	• Appreciation
Fears	• Personal rejection • Loss of stability, sudden change
Irritated by	• Insensitivity, impatience
Major Limitation	• Under pressure, can become overly willing to give • Overly modest, may deny team of their ideas • Resistance to change
Could increase effectiveness by	• Belief in themselves • Being more open to change

Conscientiousness (Compliance)

Recognise by	• Accuracy, may be cautious • Concern for high standards
Prefers work environment to be	• Structures, organised • Functional and formal • Slower pace
Gains security by	• Preparation, analytical attention to details
Motivated by	• Correctness
Measure progress by	• Getting it right
Fears	• Criticism of performance or output
Irritated by	• Surprises, unpredictability
Major Limitation	• Can become overly critical of self and others • Slow decisions
Could increase effectiveness by	• Taking risks occasionally • Being willing to compromise, being more tolerant

Communicating to a person using I behaviour

Time	• Often depends on environmental factors, level of interest • Attention will wane quickly if customer not engaged in discussion
Your planning	• Personal focus important
Your questions	• Achievements, pride, ego • Ask about personal wins
Your answer	• Personal, charisma, humour, warmth
Their preferred presentation approach	• Informal but warm • Creative, imaginative, engaging
Ensure you avoid	• Too many details • Being impersonal, aloof

Communicating to a person using I behaviour

Time	• Keep meetings/ conversations brief, make the purpose clear • Be punctual, disciplined
Your planning	• High level of preparation critical to success
Your questions	• Demonstrate knowledge of the customer's organisation and industry • Perceptive, pointed
Your answer	• Direct, brief, targeted, decisive • Don't guess, lie or evade
Their preferred presentation approach	• Formal, structured, concise • Make options clear to customer/prospect
Ensure you avoid	• Excessive small talk • Being over friendly, getting too close • Appearing disorganised

Communicating to a person using S behaviour

Time	• On time
Your planning	• Focus on the impact on people • Identify how people think and feel
Your questions	• Interested in people and impact
Your answer	• Friendly, human content
Their preferred presentation approach	• Informal, friendly • Organised
Ensure you avoid	• Rushing, urgency • Insincere • Demands for decisions

Communicating to a person using C behaviour

Time	• Disciplined, punctual
Your planning	• Critical to success-do your homework
Your questions	• Pointed, technical
Your answer	• Specific, supportable
Support required to gain agreement	• Detail oriented, step by step details • “How things work”, logic
Their preferred presentation approach	• Logical, low-key, sincere • Organised, orderly, process-oriented
Ensure you avoid	• Absence of facts, reliance on intuitive judgements • Rushing, urgency • Over-the-top hype

Read more: <https://www.assessments24x7.com/reports/DISCselfSampleReport.pdf>



Follow-up activities

Dominance

- Brief phone call/visit
- Invite to functions

Influence

- Trade shows
- Tours from other prospects/customers
- Lunch

Steadiness

- Site Visits
- Personal follow-up letters, thankyou cards

Conscientiousness

- Mail information (e.g. updates, new services)
- Regular checks that service meets their expectation

Contact Details

Sydney Main Campus

Level 1, 160 Sussex Street Sydney NSW 2000

Melbourne Campus

Level 7, 399 Lonsdale Street, Melbourne VIC 3000

Brisbane Campus

Level 1, 126 Margaret Street, Brisbane QLD 4000

Ph: 1300 780 520

Web: www.professionalyear.info

Email: py@eca.edu.au

